

film review

Run of the Myth

GHATOTHKACH:

MASTER OF MAGIC

Director: Singeetham Srinivasa Rao

The good part is we don't need Marvel or DC Comics to give us superhero ideas. We have a surfeit of men and women with extraordinary abilities—not just specialists who can either fly, or do magic, or even grow big. You would require at least three superheroes to do what Ghatotkach does in one movie. Think Superman, Harry Potter and the Incredible Hulk. The awful part is that now everyone in Bollywood now believes they can make a cartoon film. Well, it's not so easy, and this movie shows why. Partly



TWO OF A KIND: Ghatotkach with his elephant-friend Gajju

three-dimensional, partly two-dimensional, the animation lacks aesthetic appeal as well as the right proportions. A bee looks bigger than an elephant and a baby looks bigger than the giant that comes to attack it.

The story itself is super—what can beat

a genial giant, son of Bheema, who goes all out to unite his cousin Abhimanyu with the love of his life, Surekha, one of the several sideplots in the great Mahabharata. Now please, just finesse the animation technique, and we'll beat *Shrek* in no time.

by Kaverie Bamzai

dance

Steps in Time

Dancers lead culturally rich and interesting lives. Their profession entails not just the exploration and understanding of a supreme form of art but also extensive travel, which can be very educative, bringing them in contact with people from different parts of the world. Not many, though, choose to share their experiences.

Luckily, Ashish Mohan Khokar, son of Bharatanatyam exponent M.K. Saroja, has brought out a biography on her, titled *Bharatanatyam Bhakta Guru M.K. Saroja* (published by Ekah-Bios and priced at Rs 1,100), as part of his *Gurus of Indian*



RHYTHM DIVINE: Saroja

Dance series. "It is not just a story but a documentation of the traditions that have existed and the changes that have shaped the artistic arena," says Khokar. Accompanying the pictures, some dating back to Saroja's early childhood, when she was initiated into dance by Vidwan Muthukumaran Pillai, is a first-person

narrative by the dancer, now aged 78, who was recently honoured with the Legends of India Award.

In the 1950s, the legacy of colonialism and the gradual degeneration of indigenous culture prompted first-generation writers like E. Krishna Iyer, Mohan Khokar and Kapila Vatsyayan to focus on the revival of dance forms and traditions rather than on artistes. In the 21st century, though, there is a need to document the work of legends like Kathak guru Birju Maharaj and classical danseuse Mrinalini Sarabhai, who have enriched India's cultural landscape. In that sense, Khokar has bridged the gap between performance and history.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit

recommendations

Bold and Beautiful

KOLKATA Young artist Susmit Biswas is ready to make an audacious statement with his exhibition 'If You Look You May Not Leap'. Using confident acrylic brush strokes on canvas, Biswas has tried to capture a mood that encompasses the theme. The series reflects the fluidity the graduate of the Government College of Arts & Crafts, Kolkata, has perfected. At Akar Prakar, from June 7-17.



FLUID MOOD: Biswas' work

BANGALORE Nrityagram's new production, *Pratima: Reflection*, commissioned by the Joyce Theatre, New York, will premiere at a fundraiser show for the Karnataka Spastics Society. It will consist of ensemble performances as well as solos and duets by Surupa Sen—who has also choreographed the event—and Bijayini Satpathy. The music has been composed by Raghunath Panigrahi. The production has already toured the US extensively and will have several shows in Bangalore post the premiere, which will be held on May 30 at Chowdaiah Memorial.